

If you had a spare \$1000 a month, you could top up your mortgage monthly, which would save you 12 years and eight months off your mortgage and save \$212 381 in interest payments. That's a significant chunk of money and time.

Now if you invested \$1000 a month for 18 years instead of putting it into your mortgage, with a conservative annual return of 6 per cent, you'd have \$380 959 in your investing portfolio, which makes investing a better option than paying off the mortgage. But you'd still have 12 extra years to pay off your mortgage, and as rates change this could eat into your gains.

As a result, one could work just as well as the other depending on your personal circumstances. It's important to note that if you went the investment route, you'd also be taking on the risk of assuming the stock market would perform well over the 18 years, which, while likely, is not guaranteed.

In some countries, interest rates for your mortgage get updated on a regular basis while others can offer the same flat rate for 30 years (US, I'm looking at you). When your interest rates can change, so can your goals. You may decide to not focus on paying off your mortgage fast one year, but change your mind when you refix your new rate.

Some people (like my parents) don't like having debt over their heads and want to get rid of their mortgage as soon as possible. Some people (like me) are okay with a mortgage and instead pay the minimum, putting the rest into the stock market. Both these systems work for the people involved.

There are some situations where, regardless of money, you might prefer to pay off your mortgage first, e.g. if you're closer to retirement and don't want to have those repayments affecting your cash flow. Or wanting to free up your monthly income. At the end of the day, it's about finding what works for you.

Brick #3: Automate your money

I love automation. I love technology. It's arguably one of the best things to have happened to someone lazy like me. One of my older colleagues used to call us the button generation — where everything can happen at the click